

Alabama Learning Workshop

Lesson 1: Getting Started!

June 23, 2026

1 Naa!ilka *Dialogue*

Albaamo Innaa!ilka

Alabama Language

① Meet Ava!

Holchifaya Ava.

Avak aathomma imoolafon wiikahchi.

Himaakaya Albaamo innaa!ilkan sobaylihchi.

Mikkok Albaamo innaa!ilkan aabachihchi.

Himaakaya Avak bitlihchi.

Choffihchi.

Haatanahlichich.

Avak hoyaplihchi.

Chokoolihchi.

Pontokkolin oompahchi.

Nochihchi.

Her name is Ava.

Ava lives on the reservation.

Today, she is learning Alabama.

Mikko is teaching Alabama.

Now, Ava is dancing.

She is jumping.

She is spinning.

Ava is tired.

She is sitting down.

She is eating dinner.

She goes to sleep.

2 Vocabulary

Nouns

Powwow-Related

holchifa	name
aathomma imoola	reservation
Albaamo innaa!iilka	Alabama language
pontokkoli	dinner
himaakaya	now

Verbs

sobayli	to learn
abaachi	to teach
bitli	to dance
choffi	to jump
haatanahli	to spin
hoyapli	to be tired
chokooli	to sit down
Nochihchi	to fall asleep

3 Grammar

3.1 Talking About Right Now

- In English, we sometimes need to add small pieces to verbs in order to tell when something is happening.

These are sometimes called morphemes by linguists.

(1) Tanya walks

- The same is true of Alabama. Below is the recipe for how to say something is happening *right now* in Alabama. We call this the **present tense**.
- In Alabama one way about talking about the present is to use the *-hchi* suffix. This tells us that we are in the process of doing something *right now!*.

In Alabama, like in English, there are many ways of saying the same thing, sometimes. Soon, we'll meet another suffix that can also be used to talk about the present tense: *-o/-bi*. So don't be surprised if you hear an elder say something that sounds a bit different sometimes!

Present Tense Verb Sentence Recipe I

[**Verb** + **Agent** + **-hchi**]

bitli 'dance'

- (2)
- Tom dances
 - Ava dances
 - The children dances
(*posko-ha*)

- The bear (nita) walks
- Sally walks

chiyahli 'walk'

- (3)
- Jacob walks

hompani 'play'

- (4)
- The dog (ifa) plays
 - Tanya and Jackson plays
 - Diego plays

3.2 Sounds in Alabama: Learning Snotty Nose

- In Alabama questions are asked in a certain voice, a **snotty nose intonation**.
- Listen to the audio we started with again. You'll notice that all the questions are said with a certain, unique voice and the text has a ~ at the ends of questions.
- Now that we have the voice right we can add tat to the question piece *-hchi*.

This is often called nasalization by linguist.

Verbs

- choffi — to jump
- hinkahli — to wait
- ilichooyaasihli — to brush one's teeth
- intohno — to work
- chiyahli — to walk
- lawwi — to be loud

Q: Ava-**k** [Verb]-**hchĩ**?

A: Inkobi, Ava-**k** [Verb]-**hchi**

3.3 Sentence Order

- Different languages have different sentence order! In English we usually use

(5) **Subject** **Verb** **Object**

(6) **Tanya** **sees** **Ava**

- But in Alabama the words in a sentence are in a different order.

(7) **Subject** **Object** **Verb**

- So it might sound a little weird to say "Tanya sees Ava" and the sentence would be:

(8) **Tanya** **Ava** **sees**

(9) **Tanya-k** **Ava-n** **hiicha-hchi**

3.4 Case on Nouns

- In the example about you might notice that when we build a sentence there are these little pieces on the end of some words.

(10) Tanyak and Avan

- These pieces that appear on nouns are called *case*.
- Case tells us the role of the noun in the sentence: who is doing what to whom.
- The **k** tells us it is the **subject** of the sentence. For now, we can think of the subject as the noun which the sentence is "about".

- ## ★ What about situations where there is more than one noun?

* *I saw him, I helped you*

- The noun that is being **affected** by the subject is marked with **oblique case, n.**

Let's practice!

- (11) a. ifa — dog
b. wohka — bark

- (12) a. hiicha — see
b. Jacob
c. Ava

- (13) a. ʔaʔo — fish
b. foosi — bird
c. ipa — eat

- (14) a. hopooni — to cook
b. tayyi — woman
c. chassi — corn

- (15) a. mobilka — car
b. Tom
c. aabohli — wash

- (16) a. nita — bear
b. choffi — rabbit
c. maatibi — hunt